5 – The Lampstand

In Zechariah's vision (4:2), he saw a solid gold lampstand (menorah). Whether or not the lampstand depicted within the Arch of Titus is as old as the construction of the 2nd temple in the period of Zerubbabel is unknown, but the similarity of description is close.

The interior detail of the Arch of Titus, erected to commemorate the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70, offers an ancient relief sculpture of the temple menorah, which the Romans carried off.

The Complexity of Zechariah 4

Because the vision of the lampstands and olive trees are interrupted by the oracles to Zerubbabel, some translators have opted to restructure the chapter entirely.

New English Bible	New American Bible	Jerusalem Bible
4:1-3, 11-14	4:4-10	3:1-4a, 5, 4b, 6-9a, 8, 9b-10
3:1-8, 9b-10	4:1-3, 11-14	4:1-6a, 10b, 11-14, 6b-10a
3:9a		
4:10b		
4:4-10a		

However, if there is a chiastic structure in Zechariah 4, then the notion of dislocations in the text can no longer be upheld.

The Chiastic Structure of Chapter 4

A The vision of the lampstand and olive trees (4:1-3)

B…his task would be accomplished through the power of the Spirit, not human resources (4:4-6)

C…what seemed a mountain of opposition would be reduced to a flat, level plain; when the capstone was put into place, the people would shout blessings (4:7)

D…the same one who laid the foundation (cf. Ezr. 3:8-11) would also complete it as a sign of Yahweh's sovereign calling (4:8-9)

C…though some might despise the work as insignificant, everyone would rejoice when they saw in his hand the plumb line for construction (4:10)

B…the seven eyes of Yahweh (his Spirit) ranged the earth to accomplish his divine purpose (4:10b; cf. 3:9b; Rv. 1:4)

A The explanation of the lampstand and olive trees (4:11-14)

The Meaning of the Lampstand and Olive Trees (4:1-5, 11-14)

The question about the meaning of the vision is not answered until after the oracles to Zerubbabel.

- *The seven lights in the lamp represent the seven eyes of Yahweh, which in turn are symbols of the divine omniscience (4:2, 10b).*
- *The two olive trees supply oil for the lamps through two "pipes" (this word is a hapax legomenon, so translation is only a guess), and the two trees in turn symbolize the two primary leaders, Zerubbabel and Joshua (4:13-14).*
  - *Zerubbabel was from the line of David, the royal family*
  - *Joshua was from the line of Aaron, the priestly family.*

Together, they were the channels by which the Spirit would supply for God the temple he had commissioned.

Nash Papyrus containing the Ten Commandments.

Cambridge University Library

6 - The Flying Scroll

(5:1-4)

Typically, scrolls are only inscribed on a single side. This one was open and had inscriptions of curses on both sides.

- *On one side was a curse for violating the third commandment (Ex. 20:7; Dt. 5:11)*
- *On the other was a curse for violating the eight commandment (Ex. 20:15; Dt. 5:19).*

Clearly, God expected his ancient laws to prevail!

Misusing Yahweh's Name
Ex. 20:7; Dt. 5:11

The third commandment prohibits the use of God's name in any attempt to harness his power for personal ends.

The primary abuses were in oath-taking and prophecy:

- *Oath-taking ("As Yahweh lives...")*
- *Prophecy ("Thus says Yahweh...")*

7 - The Ephah Barrel (5:5-11)

The ephah barrel with the lead cover symbolized the moral deterioration of the people in the land (5:6b).

- *The woman represented the power of evil (5:7), and since she was to have a "house" in Babylon (a shrine or temple?), she probably represents a goddess figure, possibly Ishtar.*
- *Just as God had removed the remnant from Babylon so they could build Yahweh's house in Jerusalem, so now the vestiges of Babylon are removed from the land of Israel and sent back to "Shinar" (the Hebrew text reads "Shinar" rather than Babylon, possibly to link it with the great rebellion associated with Shinar in Gen. 11).*

Rockefeller Museum, Jerusalem

This cult house and figurines decorated with Persian designs and discovered near Amman, Jordan probably represents a personal shrine to the goddess.

8 - The Four Chariots (6:1-8)

Like the earlier four horsemen, the four chariots also are patterned after the Persian imperial couriers, and also as before they represent Yahweh's storm troopers sweeping throughout the world.

- *They have accomplished Yahweh's purpose by securing peace; now that the Babylonian-Persian wars were over, this peace enabled the exiles to return to Judah to rebuild their temple.*
- *Hence, if God had ordered history so as to permit the rebuilding, then the returned exiles should return to the work with all their hearts.*

Persian gold model of a chariot, 5th-4th century BC. Discovered in Afghanistan.

British Museum, London

Bas-relief of a Persian chariot from Persepolis (5th century BC) excavated by Robert Gordon in July 1811 from the palace begun by Darius I and continued by Xerxes and Artaxerxes.